TCFV EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR CONFERENCE · MARCH 2026

DEAR AI, HELP.

Strategic AI Integration for Domestic Violence Nonprofit Leadership

EXECUTIVE SESSION REPORT

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Executive Summary

Artificial intelligence is no longer on the horizon for domestic violence organizations — it is already embedded in the tools you use every day. The question facing Executive Directors is not whether to engage with AI, but how to lead that engagement with intention, equity, and the safety of survivors as the governing principle.

This report captures the substance of the TCFV Executive Director Conference AI workshop, co-presented by Gloria Terry (CEO) and Ryan Thomas (Systems Integration Manager). It is intended as a lasting reference for leaders who attended and a briefing document for boards, leadership teams, and staff.

Four Core Takeaways

1. AI is already inside your organization. Email, HR systems, and grant portals use it whether you have a policy or not.
2. Governance is the leader's job. Without explicit guidance, AI use happens anyway — and that is a policy decision by default.
3. There are hard limits. AI must never touch survivor conversations, trauma-informed assessments, or unprotected data.
4. The upside is real. TCFV has used AI to compress weeks of financial analysis into hours and sharpen grant compliance — without sacrificing accuracy.

Context: Why This Conversation, Why Now

DV nonprofit Executive Directors are navigating a convergence of pressures that have no parallel in recent organizational history: expanding compliance requirements, chronic staffing strain, funding volatility, and now the rapid mainstreaming of artificial intelligence.

The Landscape

AI is not an emerging technology for nonprofits. It is already present in the infrastructure most organizations depend on:

Email Platforms	AI drafts, filters, and summarizes your inbox continuously. Most major platforms now include AI-generated reply suggestions and automated prioritization.
Financial & HR Systems	Pattern detection, anomaly flagging, and predictive modeling are standard features in systems like QuickBooks, ADP, and Salesforce.
Grant Portals	Federal and state grant management systems increasingly use AI for compliance screening, language matching, and reporting assistance.
Survivor Data Systems	DV organizations handle the most sensitive data imaginable. This raises the stakes of every AI interaction to their highest possible level.

> *Leadership question: Will we shape AI use — or let it shape us?*

What This Session Was Not

This workshop was explicitly framed around three clarifications that matter for how leaders receive its content:

- Not about hype. The session did not promote AI as a solution to all problems.
- Not about fear. The session did not treat AI as an existential threat to the workforce.
- About leadership. The session treated AI as a leadership challenge requiring the same discipline as any governance decision.

Governance: Risks, Boundaries, and the 5-Question Test

Effective AI governance does not begin with technology decisions. It begins with organizational clarity about what the technology is for — and what it will never be for.

Known Risks

The following risks are not theoretical. Each has already occurred in nonprofit and mission-driven organizational contexts:

Risk Area	Description
Data Exposure	AI tools trained on or storing user inputs can expose sensitive organizational and survivor data if proper data security protocols are not confirmed before use.
Algorithmic Bias	AI models reflect the biases present in their training data. Outputs related to survivor populations, resource allocation, or risk assessment may systematically disadvantage already-marginalized groups.
Hallucinations	AI systems generate confident-sounding incorrect information. Financial figures, legal citations, and policy references must always be verified against primary sources.
Staff Overreliance	Staff may begin to defer to AI outputs without critical review, eroding the professional judgment that DV work demands.
Reputational Harm	A single public AI failure — a chatbot responding to a survivor inappropriately, or a grant narrative containing fabricated data — can cause lasting organizational damage.

Hard Limits: Where AI Must Never Go

The following are not judgment calls. They are categorical boundaries for all TCFV member organizations:

Three Absolute Limits

- **Survivor Conversations:** AI cannot replace trauma-informed human connection. Chatbots, auto-responses, and AI-drafted crisis messaging are never appropriate in survivor-facing contexts.
- **Trauma-Informed Assessments:** Lethality screenings, safety planning, and advocacy decisions require human judgment, context, and relationship. No AI tool is a substitute.

- **Unprotected Data Handling:** Survivor names, case numbers, and any identifying details must never be entered into AI tools without confirmed data security and compliance review.

Governing wisely means knowing what AI is for — and what it will never be for.

The 5-Question Governance Test

Before any staff member or leader uses an AI tool for organizational work, this test should be applied. A single “no” answer is a stop signal:

1	Does this task contain identifying survivor information?
2	Would I be comfortable if this input and output were made public?
3	Is this tool confirmed as secure and compliant with our data policies?
4	Will a qualified human review the AI output before it is used or shared?
5	Does leadership — and the board, if applicable — know we are using this tool for this purpose?

Silence is a policy. Without guidance, AI usage still happens.

Leaders who do not establish explicit guidance are not preventing AI use. They are simply removing themselves from its governance. The 5-Question Test is a practical mechanism for creating a consistent, communicable standard across all staff levels.

The Equity Question

AI systems do not arrive neutral. They reflect the priorities, blind spots, and power structures of the people and organizations that built them. For DV leaders serving communities that already experience systemic disadvantage, this is not a minor technical consideration.

Who built it?	Most foundational AI models were built by predominantly white, male teams at large technology companies. These teams were not designing for DV survivor contexts, rural Texas communities, or underfunded nonprofits.
Whose data trained it?	Training data systematically overrepresents populations with high digital participation and underrepresents communities facing barriers to digital access, including many survivor populations.
Who bears the risk?	Algorithmic bias compounds existing disparities. In AI-assisted resource allocation, risk scoring, or communication tools, the people most likely to be harmed by errors are those with the least institutional power.
What is your responsibility?	As DV leaders, interrogating AI tools before deployment is not optional — especially in contexts where outputs touch survivor populations directly or indirectly.

> *Equity is not an add-on. It is the lens through which we evaluate every AI decision.*

AI Demystified: The Thinking Partner Model

A persistent barrier to effective AI use is conceptual: most people approach AI the way they approach a search engine. They type a brief question, receive a generic answer, and walk away unimpressed. This framing misunderstands what the technology actually does.

What AI Is — and Is Not

What AI Is	Pattern recognition at massive scale. Probability-based language prediction. Synthesis of large text volumes. Structured drafting and summarization at speed.
What AI Is Not	Sentient or conscious. Always correct or reliable. Capable of genuine ethical reasoning. A replacement for field expertise or human judgment.

The Thinking Partner Reframe

> *You're not searching a library — you're having a conversation with something that has read the entire library.*

Search engines retrieve. AI generates, synthesizes, and reasons alongside you in real time. The difference is not cosmetic. It changes what is possible — and what is required from the person using it.

The Intern with a PhD

The most useful analogy for AI in a DV context: imagine an intern with a PhD in essentially everything — but zero field experience, zero organizational context, and no understanding of your specific community or mission. They are brilliant in the abstract and useless without briefing.

Using AI effectively requires exactly what good supervision requires: explicit instructions, defined boundaries, and your unique organizational context. The quality of what you get back is a direct function of the quality of your briefing.

The 4-Level Prompt Framework

Prompting is a learnable skill. Participants in the workshop generated real prompts across four escalating levels using their own organizational topics:

Level 1: Vague Ask	"Write something about our housing program." Generic, could be for any organization. Output: filler.

Level 2: Partial Brief	"Write a summary of our housing services for a grant report." Some context. Better output, but missing audience, tone, and constraints.
Level 3: Well-Briefed	Specific context, clear audience, defined format, stated tone, meaningful constraints. Produces genuinely usable output.
Level 4: Expert Ask	Everything from Level 3 plus: role-setting for the AI, explicit output structure, DV-specific framing, trauma-informed considerations, and Texas/TCFV context where relevant. Produces extraordinary results.

Custom Instructions: The Sandwich Board

ChatGPT, Claude, and other AI tools allow users to configure “Custom Instructions” — a persistent set of context that runs before every conversation. This is the single highest-leverage, lowest-cost action any organization can take with AI.

The workshop demonstrated this live. The same question (“What should I do if a client discloses abuse?”) produced two fundamentally different responses:

Without Custom Instructions	Generic bullet list. Clinically distant. Could have been written for a therapist, an HR manager, or a crisis counselor anywhere. No hotline. No Texas context. No DV field knowledge.
With DV Organization Instructions	Hotline first (1-800-799-7233). Trauma-informed language. Texas-specific (Texas Family Code §261). Survivor-led framing. Knows exactly who it is working for.

20 minutes to configure · Free · Runs before every conversation

Custom Instructions are the highest-return AI investment any DV organization can make today. The same model, completely different behavior — because you told it who it’s working for.

SECTION 5

Where AI Can Help: Organizational Applications

The following applications represent current, practical uses of AI for DV nonprofit leadership — each validated against the governance framework and consistent with the hard limits established in Section 2.

> **AI accelerates judgment. It does not replace it.**

Financial Pattern Analysis	Multi-year expense review, pattern detection across funding streams, and sustainability modeling. AI can identify anomalies and model scenarios significantly faster than manual spreadsheet work.
Grant Crosswalks & Compliance	Analyze multiple funding streams side by side. Identify gaps, redundancies, and requirements. Reduce preparation time for monitoring visits and strengthen reporting readiness.
Policy Drafting	Generate first drafts of internal policies, procedure documents, and board-ready summaries. AI produces the starting material; your expertise shapes the final product.
Research Synthesis	Rapidly synthesize field research, peer organization practices, and compliance guidance into usable formats for leadership decision-making.

SECTION 6

TCFV Case Studies: AI in Practice

The following two examples are drawn directly from TCFV's internal operations. They illustrate what responsible AI adoption looks like in a DV organization context — practical, bounded, human-reviewed, and leadership-driven.

Case Study 1 · Financial Pattern Analysis

CHALLENGE Multi-year expense review was consuming disproportionate staff time. Synthesizing three years of 990 tax forms and audit reports into decision-ready financial intelligence was beyond available internal capacity.

WHAT AI DID NotebookLM (Google) was used to upload 990 tax forms from 2020–2022. AI analyzed year-over-year operational expense patterns, identified three potential financial vulnerabilities, and generated a structured summary for leadership review.

RESULT Leadership received decision-ready financial analysis in hours rather than weeks. All AI outputs were cross-referenced against original 990 documents before use. Zero unverified data entered any board or leadership communication.

Case Study 2 · Grant Compliance Crosswalk

CHALLENGE Complex contract performance requirements across multiple funding streams created significant preparation burden before monitoring visits and reporting cycles.

WHAT AI DID AI analyzed funding streams side by side, identified compliance gaps, reduced preparation time substantially, and generated structured summaries of reporting requirements for each funder.

RESULT Stronger monitoring readiness, clearer reporting strategy, and significantly reduced staff time on preparation. Human expert review applied to all AI outputs before use in any compliance context.

What Both Cases Have in Common

- AI was used only on non-survivor, administrative data.
- Human review was mandatory before any output was used.
- The AI tool was chosen specifically for its controlled, document-grounded environment.
- Leadership owned the decision to use AI and the responsibility for verifying its outputs.

Prototype Highlights: What TCFV Built and Tested

Ryan Thomas presented two live prototypes developed at TCFV. These are not vendor products — they are working tools built internally to test specific hypotheses about AI in a DV organizational context.

Prototype 1: NotebookLM Financial Synthesis

NotebookLM (Google) is a highly controlled AI environment that accepts uploaded documents and generates analysis strictly constrained to those documents. It does not draw on external knowledge or hallucinate beyond the uploaded source material.

Input	Website URLs and three years of 990 tax forms
AI Environment	NotebookLM by Google — outputs constrained strictly to uploaded documents
Outputs Generated	Audio overviews, slide decks, and written financial analysis reports
Human Role	Mandatory cross-reference of all AI summaries against original 990 documents before any use
Key Discipline	Prompt construction: “Based only on the uploaded 2020–2022 990 tax forms, summarize year-over-year operational expenses and identify three potential financial vulnerabilities.”

Prototype 2: Call Craft — Voice AI Training Simulator

Call Craft is a crisis hotline training simulator developed to test the capabilities and limits of Voice AI in high-stakes DV contexts. An advocate in training practices taking a live, real-time voice call from an AI persona acting as a domestic violence survivor.

This prototype was presented not as a finished product but as an interrogation. The workshop used it to generate a structured debate about risks and power dynamics:

- What does this tool do well that no other training method can replicate?
- What is it incapable of, by definition?
- Who gains power from its existence, and who might lose it?
- What risks does it introduce that did not previously exist?
- Is it needed, or is it a technological solution to a problem that does not require technology?

Responsible Innovation Requires Interrogation

TCFV presented Call Craft to invite critical examination, not to endorse deployment. The questions raised in this session — about boundaries, power, and necessity — are precisely the questions that should precede any AI adoption decision in survivor-facing work.

Leading Your Organization Through AI

Staff anxiety around AI is real, predictable, and the ED's responsibility to address. Fear of job displacement, fear of making a costly mistake, and uncertainty about organizational expectations are all legitimate concerns that require leadership before any tool is introduced.

Name the Anxiety	Acknowledge staff concerns explicitly before introducing any AI tool. Unaddressed anxiety becomes resistance, error, or covert workarounds.
Create Safe Experiments	Designate low-stakes, non-survivor use cases for staff to try AI without fear of consequences. Experimentation requires psychological safety.
Set the Policy First	Establish clear guidance — what is permitted, what is not, and who to contact with questions — before staff experiment freely. Policy comes before permission.
Celebrate the Cautious	Reward staff who ask questions, flag concerns, and catch AI errors. Critical thinking is a feature of a healthy AI culture, not a sign of resistance to manage.

> *Staff who are skeptical of AI are doing their job. The goal is not to eliminate skepticism — it is to direct it productively.*

Recommended Actions for Executive Directors

The following actions are sequenced by readiness level, not priority. Organizations at the beginning of their AI journey should start with governance. Organizations already experimenting should ensure governance is retroactively applied.

Immediate Actions (This Month)

- Configure Custom Instructions in your organization's ChatGPT or Claude account. Takes 20 minutes. Free. Highest ROI of any AI action available today.
- Conduct a quiet audit: ask yourself and two direct reports what AI tools they are currently using for work. The answers will inform what governance is needed.
- Share the 5-Question Governance Test with your leadership team as a starting conversation, not a final policy.

Near-Term Actions (Next 90 Days)

- Establish a written AI use policy. It does not need to be comprehensive — it needs to exist. Start with what is permitted, what requires approval, and the three hard limits.
- Designate one low-stakes administrative use case for a controlled AI experiment. Identify the tool, set the boundaries, assign a human reviewer, and document what you learn.
- Brief your board. Boards are increasingly responsible for organizational technology governance. A 10-minute briefing now prevents a 10-hour crisis later.

Strategic Actions (This Fiscal Year)

- Evaluate NotebookLM for 990 synthesis and grant compliance crosswalk. Both use cases are validated, bounded, and immediately applicable.
- Develop a staff AI literacy program with a DV field lens — not generic AI training, but training calibrated to your mission and the specific risks your population faces.
- Assign ongoing AI governance responsibility to a specific role. This does not require a new hire. It requires naming someone who is accountable.

The Charge

PROTECT survivors · **STRENGTHEN** organizations · **GOVERN** wisely · **STAY** curious

AI will not replace DV leadership. Dear AI, help — but we're still in charge.

AI Tools Used in This Presentation

This workshop practiced what it preached. The following tools were used in developing and delivering the session. Each is accessible to member organizations today. Most are free.

Tool	Provider	Used For
ChatGPT	OpenAI	Drafting, ideation, and content development across session materials
Gemini 3.1	Google	Research synthesis, analysis, and content refinement
AI Studio	Google	Model exploration and developer-level testing
Claude	Anthropic	Code generation, systems design, and complex reasoning tasks
Nano Banana 2	Google	AI image generation for illustrated portraits and session visuals
NotebookLM	Google	Document synthesis — the same tool demonstrated in Prototype 1

Transparency note: Every tool listed above was used with organizational context, explicit instructions, and human review of all outputs. None were used in survivor-facing contexts.

APPENDIX A

Quick Reference: The 5-Question Governance Test

Print and post this checklist. Apply it before any new AI use case is introduced.

1	Does this task contain identifying survivor information? If yes — STOP.
2	Would I be comfortable if this input and output were made public?
3	Is this tool confirmed as secure and compliant with our data policies?
4	Will a qualified human review the AI output before it is used or shared?
5	Does organizational leadership know we are using this tool for this purpose?

A single 'No' answer is a stop signal. Pause, consult leadership, and document the decision.

APPENDIX B

Custom Instructions Template for DV Organizations

Copy and adapt this template in ChatGPT Settings → Personalization → Custom Instructions, or in Claude Settings → User Preferences. Customize the bracketed fields for your organization.

What would you like ChatGPT / Claude to know about you?

I work at [Organization Name], a domestic violence nonprofit serving [region/county] in Texas. We provide [list core services: shelter, hotline, legal advocacy, etc.]. Our mission is [brief mission statement]. I work as [your role]. Survivor safety is the highest priority in every task I bring to you.

How would you like ChatGPT / Claude to respond?

Always apply trauma-informed, survivor-centered language. Never ask for or store identifying information about survivors or clients. If any task involves survivor data, flag this immediately and decline to proceed. Always include the National DV Hotline (1-800-799-7233) when any response touches on survivor safety. Be aware of Texas Family Code §261 mandatory reporting requirements. Use plain, clear language appropriate for board members, funders, and community partners. When unsure about DV field norms, ask before proceeding.

APPENDIX C

About the Presenters

Gloria Terry · Chief Executive Officer, TCFV

Gloria Terry has led the Texas Council on Family Violence as CEO for nearly a decade, overseeing statewide policy advocacy, member support, and strategic leadership for the DV field in Texas. Her work in this session focused on governance, equity, and the leadership responsibilities that accompany AI adoption.

Ryan Thomas · Systems Integration Manager, TCFV

Ryan Thomas has served TCFV for over 18 years across multiple roles, most recently building and managing the organization's AI-powered administrative infrastructure. He manages more than $8 million in annual grants and has built over 40 production applications serving 100+ organizations and reaching 66,000+ Texans annually. His work in this session focused on practical AI demystification and live prototype demonstrations.